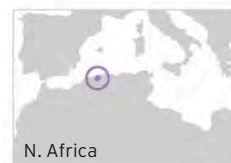




Royal Mausoleum of Mauretania

An imposing funerary monument for the first sovereigns of Mauretania



△ CONE-SHAPED MONUMENT

Built of stone blocks, the circular mausoleum stands on a square base and is capped with a tiered conical structure rising to a height of about 130 ft (40 m).

In Algeria, between Cherchell and Algiers, is the UNESCO World Heritage Site of Tipasa, containing numerous archaeological sites dating from Phoenician, Roman, Early Christian, and Byzantine times. Among them is the imposing Royal Mausoleum of Mauretania, built in 3 BCE on the orders of Juba, formerly King of Numidia, then the client king of the Roman province of Mauretania. Now known to be the tomb of King Juba II and his wife, Queen Cleopatra Selene II, it was thought to have been intended as a monument for Cleopatra and is known locally as *Kubr-er-Rumia*, “Tomb of the Roman Woman”—a reference to her parents, Mark Antony and the Egyptian Queen Cleopatra. The couple’s vaulted burial chambers at the heart of the monument are located behind heavy stone doors accessed via an internal spiral gallery.

Damaged heritage

The mausoleum incorporated elements of Numidian, Greco-Roman, and Egyptian architecture as befitted the lineage of its occupants. The vaulted burial chambers—reminiscent of those of the Egyptian pharaohs—are housed in a windowless round building, decorated on the outside with 60 Ionic columns. Typically, Numidian buildings of this type were topped with a solid monumental cone or pyramid of stone blocks, but because of the poor state of repair, this is no longer discernible on the Royal Mausoleum. The capitals of the columns have been removed, and the remains of the royal couple are missing, presumed stolen by tomb-raiders. Although under UNESCO protection since 1982, the monument has suffered badly from looting, vandalism, and neglect.